

Faster Chrome

Google releases new Chrome build which improves performance even more and integrates Flash without a plugin

3TB drives soon

Rumours about Seagate being the first to release a 3 Terabyte drive floating

Getting the **real picture**

Gaudier, brighter and sharper isn't always better...

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When you buy your new LCD or Plasma TV, you need to get an HTPC running first. TVs can be decent LCD monitors and at the same time, they are ideal for playing back high-definition content. When that's done, calibration is the next most important thing. Calibration is necessary to get the display running at its best. Now, you can go buy a hardware calibrator like the Spyder 3 Elite, which we use in the test centre for all our TV and monitor tests. They are great but no one really wants to spend another Rs. 15,000 on a device they'll probably only use once very few months.

Let's look at the best we can do without depending on such a calibrator. All you need to do is get your TV hooked up to an HTPC preferably using HDMI or Component, so that you get the TV running at its native resolution. Avoid D-Sub at all costs.

Aspect ratio and input resolution

A lot of people want to use absolutely the entire screen area no matter what they're watching. When you're watching cable TV or DTH, and forcing the TV to run the 16:9 aspect ratio resolutions of 1920x1080 or 1366 x 768 (in case of a non-full HD TV), your image is going to appear stretched. To fix this, always use the input resolution. In most TVs, you should

the find an option called Just Scan under the TV setup menu. On the computer end, set the display resolution to the native resolution. In certain drivers and displays, you might have to adjust the Overscan setting so that the image fully occupies the entire screen.

Colours tweaking

The colours are some of the most important parameters that need tweaking on a TV or LCD monitor. Now, most TVs come with controls for the colours but if yours doesn't have it, then you can make changes to the colour settings in your display driver's colour profile.

Take a printout of a reference image – preferably with a mix of many colours. This printout should be ideally taken on a good calibrated printer which will print neutral colours. Here is one sample reference image - <http://assets1.colormailer.com/web/calibration.jpg>.

Use this printed image as a reference and display the image as a full screen image using an image viewer on your PC. Start adjusting the colours by holding the printout next to the TV. Start with the red, move on to the blue and then the green. Keep in mind that changing the value of one colour affects other colour levels. This is a very subjective way of looking at things, so compare closely with the reference image.

Brightness and Contrast settings

The brightness and contrast are equally important. The chart on the following page is useful for setting up the brightness and contrast levels for your display - www.lagom.nl/lcd-test/black.php#blacktest.png. Set your brightness first to the maximum and contrast at round 50 per cent. Now, adjust the brightness in a way such that the black band at the extreme appears the darkest. Now increase the contrast such that all the blocks go darker gradually. Adjust till the white block is the brightest and all the adjoining blocks go darker in a very uniform manner.

Turning off enhancements

There are a few features advertised by TV manufacturers which apparently improve image quality. However, it isn't the case will all of these features. The noise reduction feature for example is useful

for reducing pixilation while playing low resolution videos on a large screen. With high-definition content, it's not necessary. Keeping the feature on will only make the image look softer and lose some detail.

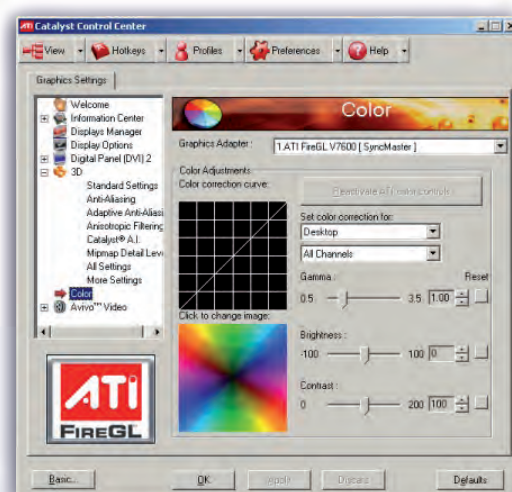
The sharpness feature is also best left at the minimum. Adding sharpness adds an edge-like feel to everything on the screen. Although, a little bit of sharpness helps HD movies look a little better, for displaying fonts on a PC display, it are really bad.

Contrast and colour enhancements features should also be left untouched. All the calibration that you do goes down the drain when you use this. Remember, we want colours to appear natural.

One of the new trends is the refresh rate of displays. With the TVs running at high refresh rates, movie frame rates go haywire. A 23.97fps movie being synchronized to run at 120Hz for example can give the impression of being smooth but there are some speeding and slowing down and problems audio syncing that take place. Preferably, turn this off as well.

Lighting setup

Lighting around your TV is equally important. If you calibrate your TV and then, have lots of sunlight coming in through the windows, you are going to see a drop in colour accuracy. Brightness and contrast settings also go out the window. When you set up your TV, make sure it isn't facing a window and there shouldn't be any bright objects or lights behind you. If it has to, make sure you have thick curtains covering them. **1**



Using the ATI Catalyst drivers to change colour levels